against minorities, and encroachment on rights like that to choice, privacy and equality.

QUICK GUN SHERIFF

In early August, the Pune police copped global spotlight with a hasty first use of the new law. It booked two individuals, including a Manchester-based pastor of Indian origin, in two separate cases, but was soon left red-faced. It had jumped the gun—the law was not yet in force! It dropped the provisions after the state clarified the law would be notified on August 28.

Protestant pastor at Mira Road: "Sometimes, halls in Christian-run schools and colleges are used for congregations. This self-declaration will prevent legal problems for them." Besides the database of regulars, newcomers at churches will be asked to sign. "It will keep them safe—and us," agrees pastor Sam Mathai of the Hope For All Ministries, a non-denominational church in Nalasopara and Vasai.

Pastor Devdan Tribhuvan, president, Christian Development Association, says instances of Hindutva vigilantes barging into smaller prayer meetings and

Takeaways

- **Churches ask worshippers to sign a form to affirm they are coming of their own volition**
- **Pastors call it legal protection in light of new anti-conversion law, amidst fears of vigilantism**
- **Some say new churches that promise magic cures more at risk—but fear hits mainstream**

Churches in and around Mumbai are now asking worshippers, including born Christians, to sign forms attesting that they are participating in religious activities with "full consciousness, free will and voluntary intention", without "pressure, inducement, temptation, lure, or threat of any kind". "If anyone makes any false allegations against me or the church in this regard, this self-declaration should be treated as evidence," it adds.

Dolphy Dsouza, spokesperson, Bombay Catholic Sabha, calls it a "precautionary measure" since church services are open to all, regardless of faith. Over 90 per cent of worshippers at churches like St Michael's at Mahim are non-Christians, he notes. Churches have been asked to instal CCTVs for safety and for evidence during vigilante attacks. The Archdiocese of Bombay covers 124 parishes and parish units, and 11 deaneries.

Says Anandrao Bokka, a alleging conversions had risen of late. In one case, a woman came to a church, asked for a prayer to be offered for her ailing son, sought religious literature—and then called her associates, who claimed she was being converted.

Advocate and activist Cyril Dara calls it a "panic reaction" to the "draconian" law and asks why no action is taken against vigilante groups. A Protestant source says churches where services are conducted in Marathi et al were more vulnerable—the Pune complaint cited the use of *abhang*, *mridanga* et al. Mainstream churches don't follow the "health and wealth doctrine" of non-denominational churches, where preachers claim to cure disease and other ills and even style themselves as prophets and apostles, he adds. Shriraj Nair of the Vishva Hindu Parishad says "harvesting of souls is a reality, this is an organised mafia...they have to stop it or else we will." ■

ON A SULTRY AUGUST NIGHT, TWO GROUPS clashed in front of the Anandapur police station on Kolkata's eastern fringes. What's new? Both groups were affiliated to the BJP. A middle-aged man was heard shouting: "*Amra daal bhaat khetey pachhina, aar ora khasir mangsho khabe?*" (We can't have dal-rice, and they'll have mutton?) The scuffle was literally over one group organising a picnic without the other's knowledge. Heads were broken, women were thrashed. When some ran to the police station, the fight travelled.

It wasn't a one-off incident. The party that came to power after years of excoriating the Trinamool Congress (TMC) for its entrenched 'goondaism', is increasingly seen to be turning into a mirror version. The accusations: *tolabaji* (protection rackets), cut money, intimidation, syndicates, local strongmen, factional violence. Exactly the things it had promised to rid Bengal of.

The state BJP is not unaware of it. Since coming to power, it has expelled some 30 workers and suspended 250 others over complaints of extortion and corruption. Recently, a miffed Samik Bhattacharya, the

